

SECTION ONE

GEOGRAPHY & ENVIRONMENT

Geography in romantasy serves a dual function. It builds a believable world, sure, but it also does something more intimate: it determines if your characters can ever meet one another. A mountain range separating two kingdoms isn't simply a border. It creates the only viable opportunity for an alliance through marriage. That isolated academy isn't just a cool setting. The isolation of the academy is the reason why your character can't leave this person who infuriates her.

Every river, every desert, every castle wall in your world will be either drawing your characters closer together or keeping them apart. Build geography with that in mind, and your setting ceases to be a passive backdrop and begins to create your story.

This section is divided into two parts:

Part One: The Foundation covers the physical reality of your world. Terrain, climate, resources, dangers, and how geography shapes where and how people live. This is the geographic baseline that exists regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Part Two: Geography & Romance covers how physical geography creates romantic tension. Separation and proximity, dangerous journeys together, entering each other's worlds, places that hold emotional meaning.

You need both.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. **Skip what doesn't fit.**

Worldbuild for its own sake if you want. A richly developed world has value beyond what appears on the page. Use the “romance connection” prompts for brainstorming if they're helpful, or leave them blank if that element is just background texture.

Come back later. If you're not sure whether something matters yet, skip it and return once your story has taken more shape.

This workbook is a tool, not a test.

How to Use This Section

Questions marked ♦ **Core** are your foundations. Answer these first and you'll have a working geography for your world. Everything else lets you go deeper where your story needs it. If you're short on time, the Core questions alone will get you writing!

Brain Dump

Before diving into the structured questions, get your initial ideas down.

What do you already picture when you think of your world's landscape?

Mountains, forests, cities, oceans, whatever comes to mind first. Don't worry about consistency yet.

YOUR ANSWER

What geographic feature matters most to your story?

The thing that creates the most tension, distance, or proximity between your characters.

YOUR ANSWER

How to Think About Geography in Romantasy

Geography in romantasy functions as a **pressure system**. The physical world can compress your characters together, force them apart, or create conditions where they must rely on each other. Before you draw a map, ask yourself: *What geographic situation does my romance need?*

Not every hill and river needs to serve the plot. But the geography you foreground, the locations where scenes happen, the terrain your characters traverse, the distances between them, should be doing something. Background geography creates atmosphere and believability. Foreground geography creates story.

The “Pressure Cooker” Principle

The best romantasy settings create friction by compressing characters together, holding them apart, or forcing impossible choices. Geography creates friction in three ways:

Proximity friction forces characters together despite themselves: a snowed-in mountain pass, a ship voyage, an isolated academy. Basgiath War College in *Fourth Wing* works because once you’re inside, there’s no leaving.

Separation friction keeps characters physically apart. An ocean, a mountain range, a magical barrier. Each departure and return becomes emotionally charged.

Resource friction forces characters to negotiate over water rights, trade routes, or contested territory. When the people your characters represent are at odds over geography, the romance must address that tension.

What seals the pressure cooker tight:

- **Physical trapping:** Islands, schools, sieges, ships, remote estates. Real boundaries your characters can’t cross.
- **Circumstantial trapping:** Wilderness requiring partnership, diplomatic missions, shared exile. Separating means failure or death.
- **Environmental trapping:** Storms, seasons, magic. Forces that make leaving impossible.
- **Social/political trapping:** Arranged marriages, hostage situations, court obligations. Leaving harms reputation, alliances, or lives.

If your characters could simply walk away, your geography needs to make that impossible, too dangerous, or too costly.

Common Geographic Patterns in Romantasy

Settings That Force Proximity

SETTING TYPE	WHY IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The Academy/Training Ground	Characters live, train, and compete in close quarters with no escape	<i>Fourth Wing, Zodiac Academy</i>
The Isolated Estate	Limited cast, limited space, limited options for avoidance	Gothic romances, <i>Pride and Prejudice</i> variations
The Ship/Caravan	Moving container with enforced proximity and shared danger	Pirate romance, trade caravan stories
The Siege/War Camp	External threat forces cooperation; death is the alternative	Military romantasy
The Prison/Captivity	Hostage and captor, shared cell, or trapped in enemy territory together	Captive romance, enemies-to-lovers
The Dangerous Quest	Mission requires partnership; separating means failure or death	Quest narratives, escort missions
The Snowed-In/Stranded	Weather or disaster traps characters until conditions change	Cabin romance, “only one bed”
The Royal Court	Political obligations, arranged proximity, can’t leave without scandal	Court intrigue, political marriage

Geographic Barriers That Create Stakes

BARRIER TYPE	ROMANTIC FUNCTION	STORY POSSIBILITIES
Mountain ranges	Separate nations/cultures; make travel seasonal	Characters from opposite sides; winter trapping

BARRIER TYPE	ROMANTIC FUNCTION	STORY POSSIBILITIES
Oceans	Create complete separation; make departure permanent	Letters across distance; the weight of leaving
Deserts	Isolate cultures; make resources precious	Oasis politics; survival journeys
Magical borders	Can be crossed only by certain people or under certain conditions	One character can cross, one can't
War zones	Make travel deadly; create no-man's-land between peoples	Enemies from opposing sides
Political borders	Crossing means treason or exile	Forbidden love across enemy lines
Cursed/Blighted lands	Regions too dangerous to cross; require special protection	Must find another way; one character immune, one isn't
Class geography	Slums vs. palace district; social ruin to cross	Wrong-side-of-tracks romance; secret meetings in between spaces

Environmental Conditions That Affect Romance

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Harsh winters	Traps characters indoors; requires shared warmth	Forced proximity; "snowed in" scenarios
Dangerous nights	Characters must shelter together after dark	Shared watch; protective sleeping arrangements
Seasonal access	Passes close, ships can't sail, travel becomes impossible	Racing against time; trapped until spring

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Resource scarcity	Sharing becomes necessary; generosity becomes meaningful	Sharing food/water; sacrifice for the other
Extreme heat	Travel only possible at night; requires shade-sharing, water rationing	Night travel intimacy; sharing precious water; heat exhaustion care
Hostile territory after dark	Monsters or predators hunt at night; must camp together for safety	One bed/bedroll situations; taking turns on watch; protective instincts
Corrupted/poisoned land	Regions that drain magic or health; must move quickly or rely on healer	Dependency on one character's abilities; racing against deterioration

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: The Rubber-Band World

Geography bends to suit the plot. Characters travel vast distances between chapters with no sense of time passing, and geographic features appear or disappear as needed. A mountain range exists to separate characters but conveniently vanishes when they need to reunite. If distance has no weight, separation has no stakes and reunion carries no emotional punch. Barriers that can be waved away whenever it's convenient are barriers readers stop believing in. The geography that's supposed to keep your characters apart needs to feel immovable, or the tension of being apart means nothing.

FIX

Establish your geography and travel times early, then let them constrain you. If crossing the mountains takes three weeks, that's three weeks of separation your characters have to live with, or three weeks of travelling together that changes everything. Let the physical world create problems you didn't plan for. Those problems often generate the best scenes.

Mistake #2: The Empty Map

You've got a map with named places, but none of them feel lived-in. The geography exists, but it doesn't affect anything. Geography should create culture, which creates characters, which creates conflict. If your geography doesn't explain why people are the way they are, your world is just a painted backdrop.

FIX

For every major geographic feature, ask: *How does this shape the people who live here?* Let geography explain cultural difference.

Mistake #3: Geography Without Emotional Resonance

You describe the setting in detail, but it's all physical. Mountains are tall, forests are dense, cities are crowded. None of it connects to how your characters feel. Setting should be emotional landscape. The place where they first met should feel different from other places. The character's homeland should feel like *home*.

FIX

Give each major location an emotional quality, and let characters experience it differently. The same castle might feel like a prison to one character and a sanctuary to another.

Geography Self-Check

Review the geography you've built so far. Check any that apply, then address the ones that need fixing.

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Rubber-Band World: Travel times or distances change to suit the plot		

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Empty Map: Locations exist but don't affect culture, conflict, or character		
No Emotional Resonance: Setting is described physically but never connected to how characters feel		

The Big Picture: Your World's Scale

◆ Core What's the geographic scope of your story?

Check the scope that best fits your story, then note the primary locations where your romance actually takes place.

SCOPE	✓	PRIMARY LOCATION(S)
Single city/location (isolated island, palace, academy)	✓	Thornwick Academy, a remote magical school on sea cliffs where students are trapped together for the term
Single city/location (isolated island, palace, academy)		
Single region (kingdom, province, territory)		

SCOPE	✓	PRIMARY LOCATION(S)
Multiple regions (nations, continents)		
Entire world (epic scope)		
Multiple worlds/realms (parallel dimensions, portals)		
Other: Describe		

If your world is large, where specifically does your romance happen?

You don't need to detail everything, just locations that matter.

List your primary and secondary locations. For each, give the name and a one-sentence description of what happens there and why it matters to the romance.

(Write your answer below)

Where do most people in your world actually live, and why there?

Cities, villages, nomadic camps? What about the geography makes settlement possible?

YOUR ANSWER

Kingdoms & Nations Overview

This is reference material. Fill in what you know now; come back as your world develops.

♦ **Core Describe your primary kingdom or nation and what defines it.**

What is it called? What is it known for? What is its main resource? How does it create or complicate your love story? If you have a second kingdom, describe it too.

(Write your answer below)

If your world has additional kingdoms or nations, describe them here.

What is each called, what distinguishes it, and how does it matter to the romance?

(Write your answer below)

How does the relationship between these kingdoms/nations affect your romance?

Are your characters from rival nations? Allied ones? Does one kingdom control something the other needs?

The political geography between nations often becomes the romantic geography between lovers.

YOUR ANSWER

Terrain Types

Only fill in terrains that matter. If your characters never see a desert, skip it.

What terrains shape your story?

For each major terrain type in your world, describe where it is and what challenges it creates.

What does it provide? How does it affect the romance?

(Write your answer below)

————— ◆ —————

You've mapped what terrains exist. Now give them names; even placeholders make your world feel real.

Naming Places

Good place names make your world feel real. You don't need to invent a whole language for this; just notice how real places get their names.

Most come from geography (Blackwood, Riverside), historical figures (Washington), or descriptions in old languages (Oxford means "ford where oxen cross"). Borrow the patterns, not the exact words.

In romantasy, naming matters most when your characters come from different cultures. Distinct naming conventions instantly signal "these people are not the same," and a character learning to pronounce names from their love interest's language, or discovering what a place name means, can be a quiet intimacy beat. If your two kingdoms share naming patterns, readers will assume shared heritage. If the names feel completely alien to each other, readers feel the cultural distance your characters have to cross.

Researching Naming Conventions

If you want place names that evoke a particular culture or aesthetic, here's how to find patterns yourself:

- **Search "[language] place name meanings"** e.g., "Old Norse place name meanings" or "Welsh place name elements"
- **Search "[language] words for [terrain]"** e.g., "Japanese words for mountain" or "Gaelic words for river"
- **Look up real places.** Search "etymology of [real place name]" to see how actual names were constructed.
- **Wikipedia's toponymy pages.** Search "[language] toponymy" for organised lists of place name elements.
- **Behind the Name.** The website behindthename.com has a place names section with etymologies.

For deeper language work, see *Section 11: Language & Communication*.

Reference: Common English Place Name Patterns

Mix prefixes and suffixes to generate names. "Ash" + "ford" = Ashford. "Black" + "moor" = Blackmoor.

SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-ham	homestead, village	Nottingham
-ton / -town	fenced settlement	Brighton
-ford	river crossing	Oxford
-ley / -leigh	clearing, meadow	Barnsley
-dale / -vale	valley	Airedale
-burgh / -bury	fortified place	Edinburgh
-port	harbour, market town	Southport

SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-moor / -mere	marshland, lake	Windermere
-fell / -mount	hill, mountain	Scafell
-holme / -holm	island, water meadow	Stockholm

Reference: Nordic/Scandinavian Place Name Patterns

Good for cold, northern, Viking-inspired settings. Old Norse roots appear in many English place names too.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-by	farm, settlement	Whitby, Grimsby
-vik / -wick	bay, inlet	Reykjavik, Lerwick
-fjord / -firth	long narrow inlet	Sognefjord
-heim / -hem	home, world	Trondheim
-berg / -borg	mountain / fortress	Gothenburg
-dal / -dalen	valley	Gudvangen
-ness / -nes	headland, promontory	Skagen
-stad / -sted	place, site	Halstead
-land	land, territory	Iceland, Gotland
-thwaite	clearing, meadow	Braithwaite

Reference: Celtic/Welsh Place Name Patterns

Good for mystical, ancient, fae-adjacent settings. Celtic names often describe landscape features poetically.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Aber-	river mouth	Aberdeen, Aberystwyth
Caer- / Car-	fort, stronghold	Caernarfon, Cardiff
Llan-	church, sacred enclosure	Llandudno

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Pen-	head, top, end	Penrith, Penzance
Tre- / Tref-	homestead, town	Tremaine
Dun- / Din-	hill fort	Edinburgh (Dun Edin)
-combe / -cwm	valley	Ilfracombe
Glyn- / Glen-	valley	Glencoe
Loch- / Lough-	lake	Lochaber
Inver- / Innis-	river mouth / island	Inverness

Reference: Slavic Place Name Patterns

Good for Eastern European-inspired settings. Slavic names often use descriptive compounds.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-grad / -gorod	city, fortified place	Belgrade, Novgorod
-ov / -ova / -ovo	belonging to (possessive)	Sarajevo, Krakow
Novo- / Novy-	new	Novosibirsk
Staro- / Sary-	old	Starograd
-pol / -pole	field	Sevastopol
Belo- / Byelo-	white	Belgrade (Beograd)
Cerno- / Chern-	black	Chernobyl
-ice / -itz	place suffix	Katowice
-sk / -sko	place/region suffix	Gdansk, Minsk
Veliko- / Veliky-	great, large	Veliky Novgorod

Your World's Place Name Patterns

Create prefixes and suffixes that fit your world's languages. What sounds right for this culture?

Create 3-5 naming elements (prefixes or suffixes) for your world's place names. For each, note the meaning and give an example of a location name that uses it.

(Write your answer below)

Name your key locations

Use the patterns above (or your own) to name the places that matter most. If you already have names, write them here and note what they mean or evoke.

Name your key locations and explain what each name means or evokes.

Consider: protagonist's homeland, love interest's homeland, where they meet, the contested territory, their special place. Which naming convention does each follow?

(Write your answer below)

Do your characters' naming conventions signal cultural distance?

If your characters come from different cultures, distinct naming patterns instantly tell readers "these people are not the same." Would someone from Kingdom A struggle to pronounce names from Kingdom B?

YOUR ANSWER

Where could naming differences create a quiet intimacy beat?

A character stumbling over an unfamiliar name, asking what a place name means, or learning that their love interest's homeland translates to something beautiful: these are small moments that build closeness. Where in your story could the act of learning someone's language or place names become a romantic gesture?

YOUR ANSWER

————— ◆ —————

Checkpoint: Your Physical World. You've mapped the big picture: terrain, resources, and key place names. Do your locations feel distinct from each other? Do the names fit the cultures? If so, you're in great shape!

————— ◆ —————

Geography determines what grows, what's buried underground, and who fights over it. Resources are where geography becomes political.

Resources & Territorial Control

Resource control drives romantic conflict: the arranged marriage to secure a trade route, the alliance sealed by sending a princess to a court she despises. Resource imbalance creates power imbalance, and that shapes every interaction between characters on opposite sides of it.

Resources & Territorial Control

Reference: Natural Resource Ideas

Use this list for inspiration when filling out the table below.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Precious Metals	Gold, silver, copper, iron ore, bronze, platinum, mithril
Gems & Stones	Diamonds, rubies, sapphires, emeralds, pearls, amber, jade, obsidian, marble, quality building stone
Textiles	Silk, wool, linen, cotton, rare furs, leather, spider-silk, feathers
Food & Agriculture	Grain, rice, olives, wine/grapes, sugar, honey, salt, spices, rare fruits, chocolate/cacao
Animal Products	Ivory, bone, whale oil, animal fat, beeswax, dyes from shells (Tyrian purple), ambergris
Plant Products	Timber, herbs, medicinal plants, rare flowers, resins, incense, tea, coffee, tobacco, opium
Fuel & Energy	Coal, oil, charcoal, peat, magical crystals, dragon-fire, captured lightning
Magical Resources	Ley line access, enchanted springs, magical creatures, spell components, phoenix feathers, dragon scales
Curiosities	Fossils, adder stones, meteoric iron, ancient artifacts, bottled starlight, tears of gods

What natural resources are geographically concentrated?

Think beyond the obvious. What does this world have that ours doesn't? What scarcity shapes daily life?

♦ **Core** What are the 2-3 most important natural resources in your world, and who controls them?

For each, note where it's found and how that control creates conflict or tension in your story.

(Write your answer below)

What geographic resource creates tension or conflict in your world?

Water rights? Arable land? Trade routes? Does the conflict show up as war, political marriage, trade embargo, or something subtler?

YOUR ANSWER

How does geographic resource control affect your characters?

Does one character's family/nation control something the other's needs? Is there territorial dispute between their peoples?

YOUR ANSWER

Continue in Section 4

Resources & Scarcity You've mapped where resources are found and who controls them. In *Section 4: Resources & Scarcity*, you'll explore how resource control creates economic stakes, cultural traditions, and romantic tension.

Cross-check: Do your resources match the economic system you'll build in Section 4? They don't have to be perfect yet, but keep an eye on consistency.

You've built the physical structure. Now step inside it. What does it actually feel like to be there?

The Sensory World

Geography isn't just what exists in space; it's how it feels to be there. Filter sensory details through your POV character's emotional state, and weave them into action rather than neutral description. Instead of "The room was cold," write "She tightened her cloak around her body, breath misting in the unheated chamber."

The Sensory World

What does your primary setting look, sound, smell, and feel like?

Close your eyes and walk through this place. What hits your senses first? What would your protagonist notice?

♦ **Core** Close your eyes and walk through your primary setting. Describe what you see, hear, smell, and feel (temperature, humidity, wind).

(Write your answer below)

How does the environment change at different times of day?

Dawn meetings feel different than midnight ones. What time of day would be most romantic here? Most dangerous?

How does your primary setting change throughout the day?

Describe morning, midday, evening, and night. What time of day best suits a romantic scene? A dangerous one?

(Write your answer below)

What's beautiful about this place?

The details a character falling in love would notice. What would make someone homesick for this place?

YOUR ANSWER

What's harsh or uncomfortable about this place?

What do people endure or complain about? What takes getting used to?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the landscape look like between your key locations?

Not every reader needs to know what's between cities, but your characters who travel there do. What's the terrain like on the road?

YOUR ANSWER

— ◆ —

The sensory world changes with time. Climate and weather shape when things happen as much as where.

Climate, Weather & Seasons

Weather and seasons shape *when* things can happen. Seasons provide deadlines, waiting periods, and markers of time passing. Weather works best in romance when it creates immediate physical problems characters must solve together.

Climate, Weather & Seasons

◆ *Core What's the overall climate?*

Climate shapes daily life, which shapes your characters' interactions. Tropical heat, bitter cold, endless rain, each creates different physical problems that your characters may need to solve together.

YOUR ANSWER

What seasons exist and how distinct are they?

Traditional four seasons? A long winter and brief summer? Magical seasons tied to something other than the sun?

YOUR ANSWER

What season is your story set in?

Seasons create mood and constraint. What does this season make possible for your romance? What does it prevent?

Pick the most story-relevant season in your world. What does this season make possible, and what does it make impossible?

(Write your answer below)

How do seasons affect life in your world?

When can armies march? When do ships sail? When are weddings held? When must everyone stay indoors?

For each season (summer/warm, winter/cold, transitional), what becomes possible and what becomes impossible in your world?

(Write your answer below)

Does the season create pressure or opportunity in your story?

Racing against winter? Waiting for spring thaw? Only able to travel in summer?

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Does your climate support the flora and fauna you'll build in Section 2? If you've got tropical creatures in a frozen wasteland, something needs adjusting!



What natural disasters or environmental threats exist?

Floods, earthquakes, magical storms, volcanic activity? What do people fear from the land itself?

YOUR ANSWER

Dangerous Regions

Dangerous regions raise stakes and force partnership. When survival becomes the priority, social walls collapse fast. Let the environment cause real damage, and let one character's competence save the other.

Dangerous Regions

What regions are dangerous or forbidden?

Every world has places people warn you not to go. What makes them deadly? What would force your characters there anyway?

♦ **Core Describe the most dangerous region in your world. What makes it dangerous, and who goes there anyway (and why)?**

(Write your answer below)

Do your characters travel through dangerous territory?

Shared danger bonds people fast. What threats would force them to rely on each other?

Plan a dangerous journey for your characters. Where do they go, and what forces them to rely on each other?

What dangers do they face? What damage does the environment cause? What changes between them after surviving it?

(Write your answer below)

Borders & Boundaries

The strongest borders aren't lines on a map. They're lines in the characters' minds. A character raised believing everyone across the mountains is a barbarian will carry that border long after the physical one has been crossed. Borders also create "in-between" spaces, neutral zones where the most honest conversations happen.

Borders & Boundaries

♦ Core What geographic features create borders?

Mountains, rivers, and oceans don't just separate land; they separate peoples, and the assumptions each side makes about the other. The feature you choose shapes how crossable the border feels.

YOUR ANSWER

How permeable are these borders?

A border that's easy to cross creates a different kind of forbidden love than one that's physically impassable. The harder the crossing, the more it costs, and the more that cost means when someone pays it.

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters come from opposite sides of a significant border?

Borders create “us” and “them.” What assumptions would each character have about someone from the other side?

What geographic or political border separates your characters, and what does crossing it cost?

Consider: legal, social, and personal consequences. Is there any in-between space where they can meet?

(Write your answer below)

What assumptions does each character carry about the other side?

The strongest borders are internal. What does each character believe, casually, without thinking, about people from their love interest’s side? And what moment first cracks that assumption?

What does your protagonist assume about the love interest’s people, and what moment shatters that assumption?

Answer for the love interest too: what do they assume about the protagonist’s people, and when does that break?

(Write your answer below)



Cross-check: Do your borders match the political system you'll build in Section 5? Your geography shapes who holds power, so these should feel connected.

Checkpoint: Constraints & Boundaries. You've defined what makes travel difficult, what seasons allow or prevent, and what borders divide peoples. Do these constraints create the friction your romance needs? If you're nodding, you're in good shape.



You've built the physical world and its constraints. Now let's consider the emotional geography, the places that feel like home, and the ones that don't.

The Pressure Cooker: Your Story

What type of geographic friction does your romance need most?

Think about the core dynamic of your love story. Do your characters need to be trapped together (proximity), kept apart (separation), or forced to negotiate over something (resource)? Most romances use more than one, but one tends to dominate.

♦ **Core** What type of geographic friction does your romance use most: proximity, separation, or resource?

How does it show up in your story, and what does it force your characters to do?

(Write your answer below)

What seals the pressure cooker in your world?

Check the trapping types that apply and describe how they work in your story. The strongest setups use more than one.

TRAPPING TYPE	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW IT WORKS IN YOUR WORLD
Physical (islands, walls, academies)		
Circumstantial (must partner to survive)		
Environmental (storms, seasons, magic)		
Social/political (obligations, hostage, arranged marriage)		

Could your characters simply walk away from each other?

If the answer is yes, your pressure cooker has a leak. What makes leaving impossible, too dangerous, or too costly?

YOUR ANSWER

Home & Belonging

“Home” is one of the most emotionally charged concepts in romance. Characters may learn that home is wherever the other person is, or discover that choosing this person means exile from everything familiar. Convey it through sensory detail and body language: a character who moves with ease on their own turf but hesitates in unfamiliar environments.

Home & Belonging

♦ *Core Where does your protagonist feel at home?*

The place that shaped them, where they feel most themselves:

YOUR ANSWER

What does home look, smell, sound like to them?

The sensory details that mean “home”:

YOUR ANSWER

Where does your love interest feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they're most themselves. How different is it from your protagonist's home?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does each character feel like an outsider?

Fish-out-of-water moments reveal character. Where would each feel uncertain, uncomfortable, or judged?

Where does each of your main characters feel most out of place, alien, uncomfortable, or unwelcome? Why?

(Write your answer below)

Entering Each Other's Worlds

Bringing someone to your home territory is an act of vulnerability. The visitor's outsider perspective reveals both beauty and flaws the native character has stopped noticing. Fish-out-of-water moments (mispronouncing a word, needing help with an unfamiliar task) create closeness because they require the trust to appear foolish.

Entering Each Other's Worlds

Does one character visit the other's home territory?

Bringing someone home is an act of vulnerability. What would they be proud to show? What would they rather hide?

When one character visits the other's world, what does the visitor notice first?

Who visits whom? What is the host proud of, and what would they rather hide? What everyday moment creates unexpected intimacy?

(Write your answer below)

What's the sensory experience of entering unfamiliar territory?

What do they notice first? What's strange? What's beautiful? What's uncomfortable?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the “native” character see their home differently through the visitor’s eyes? Pride? Shame? New appreciation? Defensiveness?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the visitor understand about their partner after seeing where they come from?

Place explains people. What becomes clear about your love interest once you see where they grew up?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel & Distance

Travel removes social boundaries and puts characters in shared vulnerability: sleeping close enough to touch, being tired and cranky, relying on each other to survive. The road makes people intimate out of necessity: shared body heat, caring for blisters, the required closeness of a small boat or narrow trail.

When you write separation by distance, show its weight through what characters *can’t* do: letters arriving too late, slow news, the pain of not knowing. A reunion after long separation hits harder than one after a short time apart.

Travel & Distance

How do people typically travel in your world?

The mode of travel shapes intimacy. Dragonback forces touching. A carriage allows conversation. Walking side by side is different from riding single-file. What does your world's travel look like, and what proximity does it create?

What is the primary mode of travel in your world, and what physical proximity does it create?

Who uses it? Is it different for different classes or regions?

(Write your answer below)

Travel Time Reference

These are real-world estimates. Feel free to adjust for your world; magic, flying creatures, or difficult terrain will change things.

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Walking (comfortable pace)	15-20 miles / 25-32 km	Healthy adult with breaks
Forced march	25-30 miles / 40-50 km	Exhausting, not sustainable
Riding (sustainable)	25-35 miles / 40-55 km	One horse, regular rest
Hard ride	40-50 miles / 65-80 km	Tiring the horse
Changing horses (relay)	80-100 miles / 130-160 km	Fresh mounts at stations
Sailing ship (favorable wind)	100-150 miles / 160-240 km	Highly variable
Carriage/wagon	20-30 miles / 32-50 km	Roads required

How long does travel take between key locations?

Distance creates stakes. A week apart feels different than a year. How painful is separation in your world?

♦ **Core** How long does it take to travel between your key locations: capital to border, one character's home to the other's, and across the dangerous region?

(Write your answer below)

Cross-check: Are your travel times consistent with your technology level (Section 9)? If your world doesn't have fast horses, that three-day journey might need rethinking.

Do your characters undertake a significant journey?

The road is where walls come down. What would a long journey together reveal about each of them?

Describe the most important journey in your story and what changes between your characters during it.

Where does it go? How long does it take? What forces them closer together?

(Write your answer below)

Isolated Locations

Isolation is romance's secret weapon. When characters can't leave, they can't avoid each other, and avoidance is the enemy of romantic development. Establish early why leaving isn't an option, then let the confined space generate its own problems: on a ship, there's nowhere to go after an argument; at an academy, the professor keeps pairing them for sparring. The setting should do storytelling work for you.

Remember: when characters finally *could* leave but choose to stay, that choice is a declaration.

Isolated Locations

What isolated locations exist?

Islands, remote estates, mountain fortresses, ships at sea, academies, pocket dimensions:

Describe an isolated or trapped location in your world and what makes leaving difficult.

What kind of place is it? Why do people end up there?

(Write your answer below)

How does the isolation generate romantic pressure?

Isolation alone isn't enough; it's the logistics of confinement that force intimacy. What about this space means your characters can't avoid each other? Think about shared meals, narrow corridors, mandatory pairings, limited beds, communal bathing, arguments with nowhere to storm off to.

In your trapped/isolated setting, what space must the characters share and what daily routine forces interaction?

Where do they go after an argument when there's nowhere to go? At what point could they leave, and what does choosing to stay mean?

(Write your answer below)

Checkpoint: Proximity & Distance. You've established how far apart your characters are and what isolates them. Does your geography force them together, keep them apart, or both? Is the pressure consistent? Both at once is perfectly fine, by the way.

Geography as Emotional Landscape

The settings you choose can amplify or counterpoint your emotional beats. A first kiss in a threatening location creates urgency; the same kiss in a serene garden conveys safety and choice. Even more subtle: characters see the same landscape differently depending on their emotional state. A person in love sees beauty everywhere; a heartbroken person sees emptiness.

Create "their place," a location that becomes sacred to the relationship. When characters return to it, a single line like "She hadn't been back to the bridge since that night" carries enormous weight without explanation.

◆ **Core** *What's the emotional quality of your primary setting?*

The emotional quality of a place shapes every scene that happens there. An oppressive setting adds urgency to a first kiss; a serene one implies safety and choice. Does your primary setting feel oppressive, expansive, peaceful, threatening, beautiful, decaying, and how does that quality interact with your romance?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the environment ever mirror or oppose your characters' emotions?

A storm during a confrontation, sunlight breaking through as characters reconcile, a wilting garden reflecting a dying relationship. Where could your setting respond to the emotional beats of your romance?

YOUR ANSWER

*Is there a location that becomes meaningful to your characters specifically?
A place they return to, a place where something changed, a place that's "theirs":*

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

How does your geography connect to other aspects of your world?

Does it create the friction type you identified? How does it explain cultural differences? How does it create power structures? How does it interact with magic? What resource or territory is contested?

(Write your answer below)

Quick Reference: Geographic Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Key location 1	The Winter Court, where protagonist is hostage and love interest is prince

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Key location 1	
Key location 2	
Key location 3	
The contested resource or territory	
The barrier separating peoples or characters	
The dangerous region	
The isolated location	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
The significant journey (from → to)	
The place that matters emotionally	
Other:	
Other:	

Map Making (Optional)

You don't need a map. Plenty of great fantasy stories were written without one.

That said, maps can help you keep travel times consistent and visualise where things are in relation to each other. If you decide to make one, let your story's needs guide you. How far is the border your characters are fleeing towards? Is the palace defensible? Where might lovers meet in secret? Build your geography around the situations your plot requires.

Map-Making Tools

Free options unless noted. Search these names online for current links.

- **Inkarnate** Popular fantasy map maker (free tier available)
- **Azgaar's Fantasy Map Generator** Procedural generation with editing
- **Wonderdraft** One-time purchase, professional quality
- **Donjon** Random generators for maps and dungeons

- **World Anvil** Worldbuilding wiki with map tools (subscription)

Map Making: What to Include on Your Map

Consider which of these appear in your world. You don't need all of them.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE LOCATIONS
Geographic features	Mountains, rivers, forests, lakes, coastlines, islands, deserts, swamps, valleys
Political boundaries	Kingdom borders, disputed territories, neutral zones, conquered lands
Cities & settlements	Capitals, port cities, border towns, villages, abandoned settlements
Trade & travel	Major roads, trade routes, mountain passes, river crossings, ports
Fortifications	Castles, walls, watchtowers, military camps, fortresses
Religious sites	Temples, shrines, pilgrimage routes, sacred groves, forbidden places
Magical locations	Ley lines, magical academies, cursed regions, power sources
Story-specific	Where characters meet, where they're forbidden to go, where they flee to

The geography of your world is about much more than where everything is. It's why your characters can't be together easily, and what they'll have to cross, endure, or sacrifice to change that. The mountain range is why two peoples distrust each other. The desert is why whoever controls the oasis controls the trade route. The isolated academy is why two people who would never have spoken are now sharing a corridor. Build geography that explains your world and creates the pressure your romance needs.

What's Next

Your geography is built! Here's where to take it:

- **Section 2: Flora, Fauna & Ecosystems** → The natural next step. What lives in the landscapes you've just created?
- **Section 4: Economy, Labour & Resources** → Your resources shape your economy. Build the trade routes, currency, and labour systems that run on what you've mapped.
- **Section 5: Government, Power & Law** → Your borders and territories shape political power. Who controls what you've mapped?
- **Section 9: Technology & Infrastructure** → How do people actually travel across, build in, and survive your terrain?
- **Section 15: Designing Your Key Locations** → Ready to zoom in? This is where you flesh out the specific places where your story happens.